MATERIALS DATA · #18 GOLD

Gold does almost nothing useful. It just hit a record price.

Only about 7% of gold does industrial work. The rest is money and ornament. Yet in 2025 the price reached about $3,300 an ounce, up roughly 38% in a year, driven by central banks and investors. The oldest money there is, surging again. Here is the data.

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01 · THE RECORD

+38 %

Gold's price rise in 2025, to about $3,300 an ounce.

Gold sat near **$1,800** in 2021 and 2022. Then it climbed, set a record in 2024, and jumped again in 2025 to a record annual average near **$3,300 a troy ounce**, with spot prices running higher still.

Mostly money, not metal.

Store of value bars, central banks, coins	**52%**
Jewellery still the biggest single use	**40%**
Technology electronics, prized for not corroding	**7%**

More than half of gold demand is now investment and reserves. Gold's main job is to hold value, not to do work.

All the gold ever, in one cube.

~22 m

cube holds every gram of gold ever mined, about 210,000 tonnes.

~1.6%

is all that annual mining adds to the world's gold each year.

Gold is almost indestructible, so it accumulates instead of being used up. The stock dwarfs the yearly flow, which is exactly what a store of value needs.

No one controls it.

China (top producer) and still only about a ninth	**12%**
Top 5 producers China, Russia, Australia, Canada, US	**41%**
Top 10 producers then a long global tail	**60%**

Gold mining is the most spread-out of any metal in this series. It is dug on every continent, which is part of why it has always been trusted.

Valued for what it will not do.

Gold became money because it does not **rust, tarnish or react**. A coin buried for two thousand years comes out gleaming.

It is rare but not impossibly so, dense and easy to recognise, and it can be divided and recombined without loss. Almost every gram ever mined still exists, so the supply is stable and slow-growing. Every civilisation, independently, reached for the same metal.

Bought by banks, not jewellers.

This rally was not about ornament. As prices rose, **jewellery buying fell about 20%**. The buyers were **central banks**, adding to reserves and diversifying away from the US dollar, and **investors**, whose holdings in gold funds rose more than **twenty-five fold** versus a year earlier.

When confidence in currencies and markets cools, money flows back into gold.

A thermometer for trust.

Gold has no supply shock to fear and no single country to depend on. Its price is not really about the metal at all. It is a reading of how much confidence the world has in everything else.

In 2025 that reading hit a record. The metal did not change. Our certainty did.

Sources: USGS Mineral Commodity Summaries 2026 (gold) and the World Gold Council (consumption split, above-ground stock, central-bank and fund flows).

That's the metals that built the world. The series goes on.

I'm a materials engineer turned data analyst, breaking down one material at a time: the numbers, the science, and why it matters. Eighteen so far, from steel and aluminium to tungsten, uranium and gold. Tell me which material you want next, and follow along.

Interactive dashboard + data on GitHub

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